On similar lines, several allegations of corruption accounting for over ₹2,000 crore were made against the West Bengal government. Some agencies were favoured for procuring medical items. The agencies failed to meet the standard quality of the supplied items and after multiple complaints and reports in the media, West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee formed a three-member panel under the supervision of the chief secretary to investigate the irregularities.[34] Once again, it remains to be seen how fairly the committee will evaluate its own government's wrongdoings, particularly since the chief secretary's political affiliations came to light when he failed to attend a meeting chaired by the prime minister in the visit to the state, thus breaking protocol during early 2021.[35]

Even in BJP-ruled states like Himachal Pradesh, purchase of PPE gear of about ₹1 crore was made without keeping due processes in mind, favouring two organizations pitched for by a certain middleman. When the allegations surfaced, a top health official was arrested and five days later, the then state BJP party president who had links to the middleman resigned.[36]

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14 APRIL 2020

INDIA | 9,734 ACTIVE CASES | 394 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,413,911 ACTIVE CASES | 137,794 DEATHS

The 21-day lockdown which the prime minister had put in place was to end today. The prime minister, after speaking with the chief ministers to get an update on the status of upgradation of health infrastructure and the spread of the contagion on ground, was urged by them to extend the lockdown. However, after careful deliberation with the health authorities, he was of the opinion that those districts which were not impacted by the contagion must be allowed to operate essential economic activities. He felt that a 'one-size-fits-all' approach shouldn't be used. This district-by-district analysis would be done in the upcoming week and districts would be carefully categorized as red, orange or green based on their caseload. The categories naturally would be dynamic as caseloads would go up or down/fluctuate. Not only did this announcement boost the spirits of people who were low on morale because of losing work but also of local governments who would now strive